Sterling Stablecoins On-Chain:
A Multi-Source Verification Study of Market Structure, Regulatory Models and Payment Use

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Abstract

Sterling-denominated stablecoins remain a small and insufficiently documented segment of the digital asset market. Inconsistent public data, diverse issuance arrangements, and uncertainty about transaction activity complicate their assessment. This study examines six British pound stablecoins across five blockchains using blockchain explorers, official issuer documentation, third-party listings, and daily market data covering approximately one year. First, the combined market capitalization of the six tokens was approximately 30 million United States dollars, about 0.01 percent of the dollar stablecoin market. Second, the tokens follow four distinct issuance models with differing consumer protection, and neither of the two UK-based issuers offers deposit-compensation coverage. Third, supply and ownership were highly concentrated, with one token representing approximately 87 percent of the market, and transfer counts did not reliably indicate payment use: some activity was consistent with automated trading, while 78 percent of one token's transactions over twelve months were card payments made by a small but recurring group of users whose activity declined during the period. Conflicting public figures and issuer information further demonstrated the need for independent verification. These findings inform the assessment of market maturity, consumer protection, and transparency in the British pound stablecoin ecosystem and the wider debate on a digital pound.

Keywords: stablecoins; sterling; on-chain analysis; payments; digital pound; data quality.

1 Introduction

Sterling-denominated stablecoins are emerging within a broader debate about the future of digital money in the United Kingdom. The Bank of England is considering whether to introduce a digital pound while developing a regulatory regime for systemic sterling-denominated stablecoins [1, 2]. These initiatives reflect concerns about the role of privately issued digital money, financial stability, and public confidence in payment systems. The stablecoin market is dominated by dollar-denominated stablecoins [3], which raises questions about whether digital transactions could increasingly rely on foreign-currency instruments rather than sterling. Understanding the scale, structure, and actual usage of GBP stablecoins is therefore relevant to assessing their potential role in the UK's evolving digital financial ecosystem.

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Despite this policy relevance, establishing a reliable picture of the GBP stablecoin market remains challenging. Public market-data platforms can report inconsistent market capitalizations and trading volumes, while token names, contract addresses, and issuer information may change or conflict across sources. Blockchain explorers provide on-chain information, but interpreting supply, holder concentration, and transaction activity requires careful verification and consideration of token-specific characteristics. Community-maintained analytics dashboards offer a useful starting point, yet their coverage and query logic also require scrutiny [4]. In particular, the relationship between reported transfer counts and genuine economic activity remains uncertain when automated trading or intermediary transaction mechanisms may influence observed patterns. We are not aware of a study that combines verified token identification, issuance-model classification, and usage analysis for GBP stablecoins.

This paper proposes a multi-source verification protocol for multi-chain stablecoin data and applies it to six GBP stablecoins across five blockchains, combining blockchain explorers, official issuer documentation, third-party listings, one year of daily market data, and twelve months of transfer data. Potential automated activity is interpreted cautiously and is not treated as conclusively identified bot behavior.

The paper makes four contributions:

- It proposes a reusable multi-source verification protocol (Table 1) for identifying multi-chain stablecoin deployments, and applies it to produce a verified register of six GBP stablecoins, including naming changes and contract migrations.
- It identifies four issuance models and examines their differing regulatory arrangements and implications for consumer protection.
- It analyzes supply growth and holder concentration, and measures payment use over twelve months by classifying more than 84,000 transfers of one token, showing that most of its activity consists of card payments.
- It documents inconsistencies in public market data, issuer attribution, and community analytics queries, highlighting the need for transparent and reproducible verification.

Together, these contributions provide an evidence-based assessment of the GBP stablecoin market and a method that can be reused for other small, multi-chain stablecoin markets.

2 Background and Related Work

Recent research has examined stablecoins from both on-chain and monetary-policy perspectives. Zhu et al. analyze temporal blockchain transaction networks involving major stablecoins and show how network-based measures can reveal behavioral changes and anomalies around market events [5]. Complementing this approach, Schär et al. distinguish individual stablecoin transfer events from complete blockchain transactions, demonstrating that many transfers occur within complex operations involving trading, lending, arbitrage, and liquidity provision [6]. Their findings are particularly relevant to the present study: transfer counts alone may not provide a reliable measure of payment activity. Studies of stablecoin design show that price stability depends on investors' access to arbitrage with the issuer [7], and that many stablecoins fail or lose their peg over time [8]; a recent systematization of 157 studies and 95 stablecoins describes stability as a fragile, emergent state rather than an inherent property [9]. Reported on-chain activity is also distorted by automated trading. Arbitrage bots are widespread on decentralized exchanges [10], and wash trading has been estimated

at more than 70% of reported volume on unregulated centralized exchanges [11]. Visa's adjusted stablecoin metrics, which filter out bot-like activity, show that retail-sized transactions accounted for less than 1% of adjusted stablecoin volume in the twelve months to March 2025 [12]. However, this literature primarily examines major dollar-denominated stablecoins, leaving smaller national-currency markets less explored.

Regulatory research highlights the relationship between private digital money, financial stability, and central bank money. The Bank for International Settlements' survey of central banks documents widespread CBDC exploration and reports that stablecoins remain rarely used for payments outside the crypto ecosystem [13]. Its subsequent survey also identifies the preservation of central bank money as an important motivation for CBDC development [14]. In the United Kingdom, the Bank of England has proposed a regulatory framework for systemic sterling-denominated stablecoins, reflecting the need to establish safeguards for stablecoins that may become important in payment systems [2]. Economic analyses compare stablecoins with the private banknotes of the nineteenth century, whose issuers resembled unregulated banks [15], and the BIS has argued that stablecoins fall short of the singleness, elasticity, and integrity required of the core of the monetary system [16]; earlier BIS work proposed proportionate regulation and embedded supervision [17]. In the European Union, the Markets in Crypto-Assets Regulation classifies tokens referencing a single official currency as e-money tokens, which must be issued by credit or e-money institutions and be redeemable at par at any time [18]. In the UK, the Financial Conduct Authority published final rules for qualifying stablecoin issuers in June 2026, which will apply to firms authorized under the new regime from 25 October 2027 [19]. These policy developments provide the regulatory context for examining the legal and operational differences between existing GBP stablecoins.

Research on non-USD stablecoins is also developing. A 2026 European Central Bank analysis examines how euro-denominated stablecoins could affect sovereign bond markets, showing that the implications depend on issuer type, reserve composition, and the sources of stablecoin demand [3]. The Dune Research report *Beyond Dollarization* provides a broader industry analysis of local-currency stablecoins across payments, foreign exchange, treasury activity, and decentralized finance [20]. Nevertheless, neither source provides the token-level, cross-chain verification of GBP stablecoins undertaken here.

The closest prior work is a community-maintained Dune dashboard on GBP stablecoins [4], whose coverage and query logic we review in Section 4.5.

3 Data and Method

3.1 Token Identification

We identified six British pound-denominated stablecoins using a cross-source process. Token names and tickers were treated as initial identifiers rather than evidence of identity, since similarly named assets, rebranding, and contract migrations can complicate identification. Candidates were checked against official issuer websites and documentation, blockchain explorer records, and third-party market-data listings, and contract addresses were recorded for each deployment to support reproducibility. The resulting sample comprised GBPA, tGBP, GBPe, VGBP, GBPm (formerly the Celo British Pound, cGBP), and poundtoken (1GBP), observed across Ethereum, Gnosis, Solana, Base, and Celo. For GBPe, both the current contract and a legacy pre-migration contract identified in Dune's decoded tables were recorded, and each VGBP deployment was treated as a separate chain-level instance of the same asset. The relationship between poundtoken (1GBP) and the earlier Blackfridge GBPT was not independently established. The sample is therefore a verified set for the stated observation period rather than an exhaustive register of all GBP-linked tokens.

Table 1: Multi-source verification protocol applied to each stablecoin deployment

Step	Action
1	For each chain on which the token is reported, locate its contract address in the chain's blockchain explorer.
2	Record the token's name, symbol, decimals, supply, and holder count.
3	Confirm the address and issuer against at least one further independent source, so that each is supported by two sources (issuer documentation preferred).
4	If sources conflict, prefer the live explorer and the official issuer source, and log the discrepancy.
5	Check for renamed tokens and for migrated or legacy contracts, and record each separately.
6	Sum chain-level supplies, each scaled by its own decimals, and compare the total with the reported supply.

Table 2: Sources used and discrepancies resolved by the verification protocol

Token	Sources used	Discrepancy found and resolution
tGBP	Etherscan; issuer website; CoinGecko	Issuer named as Transfero by a secondary source; official site names BCP Technologies Ltd
GBPA	Etherscan; issuer website; Dune dashboard	Ethereum supply (1.0M) differs from multi-chain total (1.9M); both recorded
GBPe	Gnosisscan; issuer documentation; CoinGecko; Dune tables	Contract migration; legacy (v1) and current (v2) contracts confirmed and recorded separately
GBPm	Celoscan; DefiLlama; GeckoTerminal	Renamed from cGBP; outdated search snippet; unrelated "CGBP"-prefixed pools excluded
VGBP	Solscan; Basescan; Celoscan; CoinGecko	Decimals differ by chain (9 vs. 18); chain supplies reconcile with reported total
1GBP	Etherscan; linked website; Dune query	Symbol differs from original GBPT; linked domain no longer operated by an issuer

Candidate tokens were drawn from CoinGecko's GBP stablecoin category, keyword searches on Dune, and news coverage of GBP stablecoins. A token was included if (i) its issuer, protocol, or market listing presented it as a GBP-denominated stablecoin, and (ii) at least one contract address could be located and inspected in a public blockchain explorer. Tokens were retained regardless of current activity, so the dormant 1GBP was included to reflect the full market structure. Tokens with incomplete or conflicting issuer attribution were retained when on-chain and third-party evidence supported their relevance, with the remaining uncertainty recorded explicitly. Trading pools and tokens that matched only by name or symbol were excluded. Because the search was exploratory, these criteria were applied during data collection and are documented here retrospectively.

3.2 Verification and Triangulation

For each token, we examined the on-chain name, symbol, decimals, supply, and holder count using the relevant blockchain explorer: Etherscan (Ethereum), Gnosisscan (Gnosis), Solscan (Solana), Basescan (Base), and Celoscan (Celo). We compared these observations with CoinGecko and official issuer websites or documentation to confirm token identity, contract addresses, and issuer details. Our rule was to require confirmation from at least two independent sources rather than rely on a token name, search result, or listing alone. Where sources disagreed, we prioritized live blockchain explorers and official issuer information. For example, one secondary source named Transfero as the issuer of tGBP, whereas the official Tokenised GBP website identified BCP Technologies Ltd, which we recorded as the issuer. Table 1 summarizes the protocol; steps 1, 2, and 6 rely only on public explorer data and could be automated through explorer interfaces, which we leave to future work. Table 2 reports the sources used and the discrepancies it resolved for each token.

3.3 Reconciliation Across Chains

For multi-chain tokens, we examined the supply separately on each blockchain and compared the combined total with CoinGecko's reported supply. For VGBP, the verified supplies were 72,689.71 on Solana,

25,299.32 on Base, and 28,606.18 on Celo, giving a combined total of 126,595.21, consistent with CoinGecko's reported total of 126,595. This reconciliation confirmed that these three chains accounted for the full VGBP supply reported by CoinGecko at the time of verification. We also found that decimal precision varied by chain: VGBP uses 9 decimals on Solana and 18 on both Base and Celo. Therefore, supply calculations must apply the correct decimal divisor separately on each chain before the results are combined.

3.4 Market Data

We collected daily market capitalization, trading volume, and closing-price data for tGBP from CoinGecko [21], covering 12 November 2025 to 15 October 2026. We focused on tGBP because it represented approximately 87% of the GBP stablecoin market at the time of verification (October 2026). To estimate its supply, we divided market capitalization by the closing price, producing an implied supply figure rather than an exact on-chain count, as the reported price was rounded to two decimal places. We expressed supply in token units (approximately GBP, given the 1:1 peg) because USD market capitalization can fluctuate with the GBP/USD exchange rate even when token supply remains unchanged. We excluded the first two days, when market capitalization was not tracked, and the final day, which contained incomplete daily data.

3.5 Transfer Classification

To measure how GBPe was used, we collected all GBPe transfers on Gnosis between 17 October 2025 and 16 October 2026 from the public Blockscout explorer interface [22], which reports for each transfer the transaction hash, timestamp, sender, recipient, amount, and the method called by the transaction. After removing 501 duplicate records produced by pagination, the dataset contained 84,382 transfers in 67,494 distinct transactions. We classified a transaction as a card payment if it called method `0x8a320255`, the method of a transaction that the explorer tagged "Gnosis Pay" and that executed a contract labelled "Spender Module". Transfers to or from the zero address were classified as mints or burns, transactions calling CoW Protocol settlement methods as trades, and the remainder as other decentralized-exchange, aggregator, or direct transfers. Transfers below 0.001 GBPe were flagged as dust. The collection and classification scripts are publicly available.

3.6 Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, most market and on-chain figures represent a snapshot from 13–15 October 2026 and may change as blockchain activity evolves. Second, holder counts, whale concentration, and Gini coefficients were taken from explorer-reported metrics rather than independently recalculated. Third, the analysis covered selected chains: GBPe was examined on Gnosis, while tGBP holder concentration was assessed on Ethereum, although both tokens operate across multiple chains. Fourth, the card-payment classification relies on a method identifier confirmed through a sampled transaction rather than on issuer data, and covers GBPe on Gnosis only, excluding its other chains and the legacy contract; bot-like activity in VGBP was identified from a small sample of recent transfers. Fifth, discrepancies in the existing @duneuk query[4] were identified from its code, but their effect on its outputs was not tested by execution. Finally, transaction-level analysis was carried out for GBPe only; extending it to the other tokens remains future work.

Table 3: Sterling stablecoins verified in this study (13–15 October 2026)

Token	Issuer	Model	Chain(s) verified	Supply	Holders	Status
tGBP	BCP Technologies Ltd	UK MLR registration, not e-money	Ethereum[a]	20.0M[b]	309	Active, low turnover
GBPA	Agant Finance Ltd	UK MLR registration	Ethereum[a]	1.0M[d]	2	Active, concentrated
GBPe	Monerium	E-money token	Gnosis[a]	505K	1,302	Active, many transfers
GBPm	None (Mento Protocol)	Crypto-backed (CDP)	Celo	235K	307	Shrinking
VGBP	VNX Global Ltd	Offshore license (Bermuda)	Solana, Base, Celo	127K	572/287/20	Bot-dominated (Solana)
1GBP	Unconfirmed[c]	Unknown	Ethereum	46K	177	Dormant

[a]Also deployed on other chains not verified here. [b]Total across chains (CoinGecko); other figures are for the chain(s) verified.

[c]Likely the original GBPT (Blackfridge); not confirmed. Holders for VGBP listed per chain (Solana/Base/Celo). [d]About 1.9M across all chains [23].

4 Findings

4.1 Market Size

On 13 October 2026, CoinGecko reported a total market capitalization of approximately $31.8 million for GBP stablecoins. Summing coin-level figures for the six tokens gives approximately $30.2 million, broadly consistent with the category total; this sum uses CoinGecko coin pages where available and, for GBPA, a multi-chain supply of about 1.9 million tokens reported by a community dashboard [23]. Compared with dollar-denominated stablecoins, with a market capitalization of around $300 billion [3], GBP stablecoins accounted for approximately 0.01%. Even euro-denominated stablecoins, at around EUR 450 million in January 2026 [3], were more than ten times larger. The market was dominated by a single token: tGBP represented approximately 87% of the GBP stablecoin market.

4.2 Four Issuance Models

The six tokens examined in this study represented four distinct issuance models, alongside one dormant token whose issuance arrangements remained unclear. First, tGBP and GBPA operate under registration with the Financial Conduct Authority under the UK Money Laundering Regulations (MLR), which should not be confused with authorization as an e-money issuer. Second, GBPe follows an e-money model, placing it in a distinct legal category. Third, VGBP is issued by a Bermuda-based entity licensed by the Bermuda Monetary Authority, placing its regulatory framework outside the UK. Finally, GBPm is a crypto-collateralized stablecoin minted through collateralized debt positions (CDPs) rather than issued by a conventional company. These differences show that the label "GBP stablecoin" does not imply uniform legal status or consumer protection. Table 3 summarizes the tokens, their issuance models, and relevant regulatory characteristics.

4.3 Supply Growth and Concentration

Fig. 1 shows that the implied supply of tGBP rose from approximately 1.1 million tokens to a peak of about 25.5 million in mid-2026, before falling to around 20 million. Most of this change occurred on six individual days, including a decline of approximately 19% on 8 August 2026, equivalent to roughly £5 million in implied redemptions. This step-like pattern is consistent with large issuance or redemption events rather than gradual adoption, although the data alone cannot establish the actors involved. Holder data also reveal substantial concentration. On Ethereum, GBPA had just two holders, with one holding approximately 99.99% of supply. For tGBP, the top ten of 309 holders controlled around 96%, with a Gini coefficient of approximately 0.98. VGBP on Base showed a similarly high Gini coefficient of approximately 0.995. Together, these patterns suggest that supply changes and ownership were dominated by a small number of

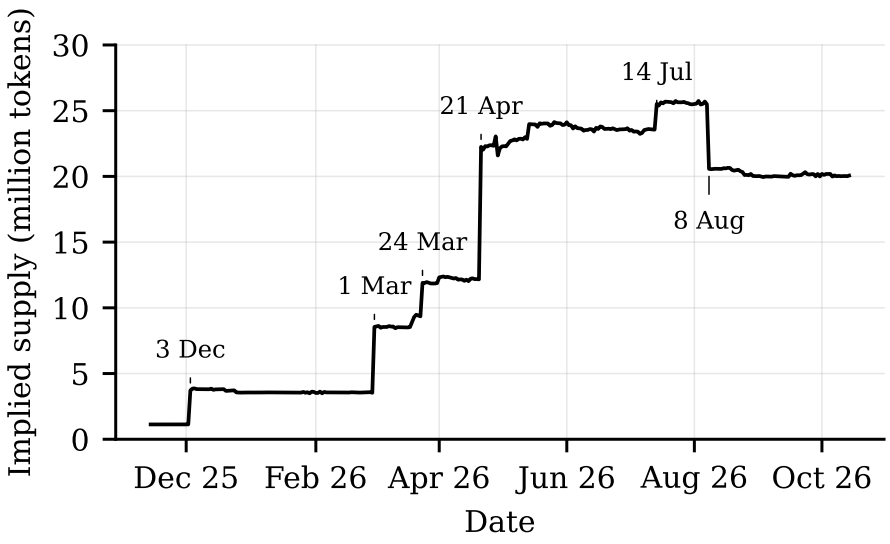


Figure 1: Implied supply of tGBP (market capitalization divided by closing price), 14 November 2025 to 14 October 2026. Labels mark the six days with the largest changes. Source: CoinGecko daily data.

large holders rather than broadly distributed participation.

4.4 Usage, Bot Activity, and Card Payments

The usage indicators reveal a mismatch between market size and transaction activity. Although tGBP was the largest token, its average daily trading volume was approximately 0.42% of its market capitalization over the year to October 2026, rising to 0.76% over the most recent 30 days. GBPe, by contrast, had 1,302 holders on Gnosis, the largest holder count among the tokens examined, and 203,735 transfers, despite a supply of only about 505,000 tokens. VGBP recorded 265,177 transfers on Solana, yet the ten most recent transfers inspected on 13 October 2026 involved very small amounts (approximately $0.12–$0.26) and repeated movements between the same wallets and the Raydium and Meteora decentralized exchanges. This pattern is consistent with automated trading or arbitrage activity, although it does not by itself prove that the transfers were automated. On 13 October 2026, the main trading pool for GBPm recorded zero volume over the preceding 24 hours. GBPe showed a different pattern. Over twelve months, 52,662 of 67,494 GBPe transactions (78%) were card payments executed through the Gnosis Pay Spender Module, all of which moved GBPe from users' wallets to a single settlement address. A sampled payment was submitted by an externally owned address with more than 3.9 million transactions, consistent with a relayer that submits card payments on users' behalf. The median payment was 11 GBPe, typical of everyday spending, and payments totalled about 3.0 million GBPe. Usage was broad rather than concentrated: 488 wallets made card payments, 347 of them ten times or more, and the ten most active wallets accounted for only 14% of payments, in contrast to the concentration of token holdings described above. Fig. 2 shows, however, that activity declined during the period: monthly card payments fell by 59% between November 2025 and September 2026, and active paying wallets fell by 39% from their December 2025 peak. By value, card payments accounted for only 13% of non-mint, non-burn transfer volume, because trades were larger. Dust transfers below 0.001 GBPe made up 2.7% of transfers, mostly within decentralized-exchange activity. These findings show why transfer counts alone are insufficient measures of economic use.

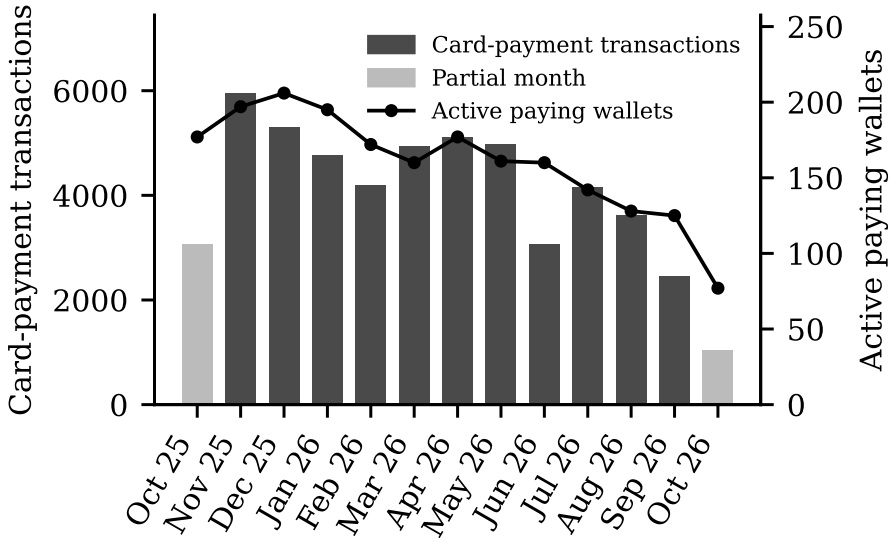


Figure 2: Monthly GBPe card-payment transactions on Gnosis and the number of distinct wallets making them, October 2025 to October 2026. The first and last months are partial. Source: Blockscout transfer data, classified by method.

4.5 Data Quality in Public Sources

Cross-checking public sources revealed material inconsistencies in reported market data and token information. CoinGecko reported different tGBP market capitalizations on its GBP category page and its tGBP coin page ($31.2 million versus $26.4 million), while VGBP's daily trading volume was given as $509,000 in the category summary but $5.65 on the coin page. Other issues included an outdated search snippet for GBPm supply, a reported GBPe all-time high of $53.28 that appeared anomalous, and a 2026 exchange blog post describing GBPT as popular although on-chain data showed the token to be largely dormant. Issuer attribution also conflicted: one secondary source named Transfero for tGBP, whereas the official issuer website identified BCP Technologies Ltd. In the existing @duneuk supply query [4], the tGBP contract address differs from the verified address by two transposed characters, and tGBP amounts are divided by 10^6 although the verified contract uses 18 decimals; the query also omits GBPA, GBPe, and Solana VGBP. These discrepancies are visible in the query text; their effect on the dashboard's outputs was not tested by executing the query. These discrepancies mirror wider concerns about inflated volumes in crypto markets [11, 12]. We therefore prioritized blockchain explorers and official issuer documentation when resolving discrepancies.

5 Discussion

The findings raise important questions about consumer protection. The UK-based issuers of tGBP and GBPA both operate under MLR registration, and the issuer of tGBP states that it is not e-money. Neither token offers Financial Services Compensation Scheme (FSCS) protection, and GBPA is also reported to fall outside the Financial Ombudsman Service (FOS). By contrast, e-money tokens under the EU framework must give holders a right of redemption at par at any time [18], and the UK's regime for qualifying stablecoins will not apply until October 2027 [19]. Consequently, users may face significant recovery risks if an issuer fails,

particularly where no equivalent safeguarding or compensation mechanism applies. These findings highlight the importance of distinguishing regulatory registration from the protections that users may reasonably associate with regulated financial products.

The diversity of issuance models also has implications for the Bank of England's proposed regime for systemic sterling stablecoins [2]. Under the proposed framework, stablecoins that are not widely used for payments would be regulated by the Financial Conduct Authority alone [2]; given their current scale, the tokens reviewed here appear to fall into this category. This study identified four distinct models, ranging from MLR-registered issuers and e-money issuance to offshore licensing and crypto-collateralization. Such differences suggest that a single "GBP stablecoin" label can obscure substantial variation in legal status, backing arrangements, and consumer protection. Clear regulatory classifications and consistent disclosure requirements may therefore help users understand the risks associated with individual tokens.

The market's limited scale and concentrated ownership further qualify its current monetary significance. GBP stablecoins were equivalent to approximately 0.01% of the dollar-denominated stablecoin market, while tGBP accounted for around 87% of the GBP segment. The contrast between bot-like activity in VGBP and card-payment activity in GBPe also shows that small sterling stablecoins can play very different roles. GBPe demonstrates that a sterling stablecoin can support recurring retail payments, but the scale is small, a few hundred active wallets, and declining, which suggests that payment use has not yet reached self-sustaining adoption. The share of payments in GBPe activity nevertheless contrasts with dollar stablecoins, where retail-sized transactions form a very small part of adjusted volume [12]. Combined with uneven trading activity and highly concentrated holdings, these findings suggest that GBP stablecoins have not yet achieved the broad-based adoption needed to play a significant monetary role. The dormancy of 1GBP and the contraction of GBPm are consistent with evidence that many stablecoins fail or fade over time [8]. Their small size relative to dollar-denominated stablecoins[3] suggests that sterling currently has a very limited on-chain presence, a question relevant to the wider debate on the digital pound [1].

Finally, inconsistencies across market-data platforms, issuer information, and public analytics queries indicate that transparency remains a practical challenge. Conflicting market capitalizations, trading volumes, and issuer attributions can complicate comparisons and policy assessment. A standardized disclosure framework and an authoritative register of sterling stablecoins may improve data reliability, regulatory oversight, and public understanding. Further research using transaction-level data would help distinguish genuine payments from automated trading and clarify how far reported activity reflects economic use.

6 Conclusion and Future Work

This study examined six GBP stablecoins across five blockchains, assessing their issuance models, supply dynamics, holder concentration, transaction activity, and public data quality. The findings reveal a small market dominated by tGBP, highly concentrated ownership, and substantial differences in issuance and regulatory arrangements. Transfer counts alone proved insufficient to establish genuine economic use, while inconsistencies across public sources highlighted the need for independent verification. A twelve-month analysis of GBPe further showed that 78% of its transactions were card payments made by a small, recurring, and declining group of users, demonstrating that sterling stablecoins can support everyday payments but have not yet achieved broad adoption. These results suggest that market size, activity, and legal status must be assessed together to understand the GBP stablecoin ecosystem and to inform the policy debate on sterling stablecoins and the digital pound. Future work will extend transaction-level analysis to the other

tokens and chains, examine the causes of the decline in GBPe card payments, compare GBPe with EURe from the same issuer, and execute the existing @duneuk query to measure the effect of the discrepancies identified.

Data Availability

The verified token register, research logbook, market and transfer data, scripts used to collect and classify the data, and supporting evidence are publicly available at `https://github.com/vijetarajput/gbp-stablecoin-analysis`.

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Author Contributions

VR is the sole author and carried out the data collection, verification, and analysis.

Conflict of Interest

The author declares that they have no known conflicts of interest as per the journal's Conflict of Interest Policy.

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